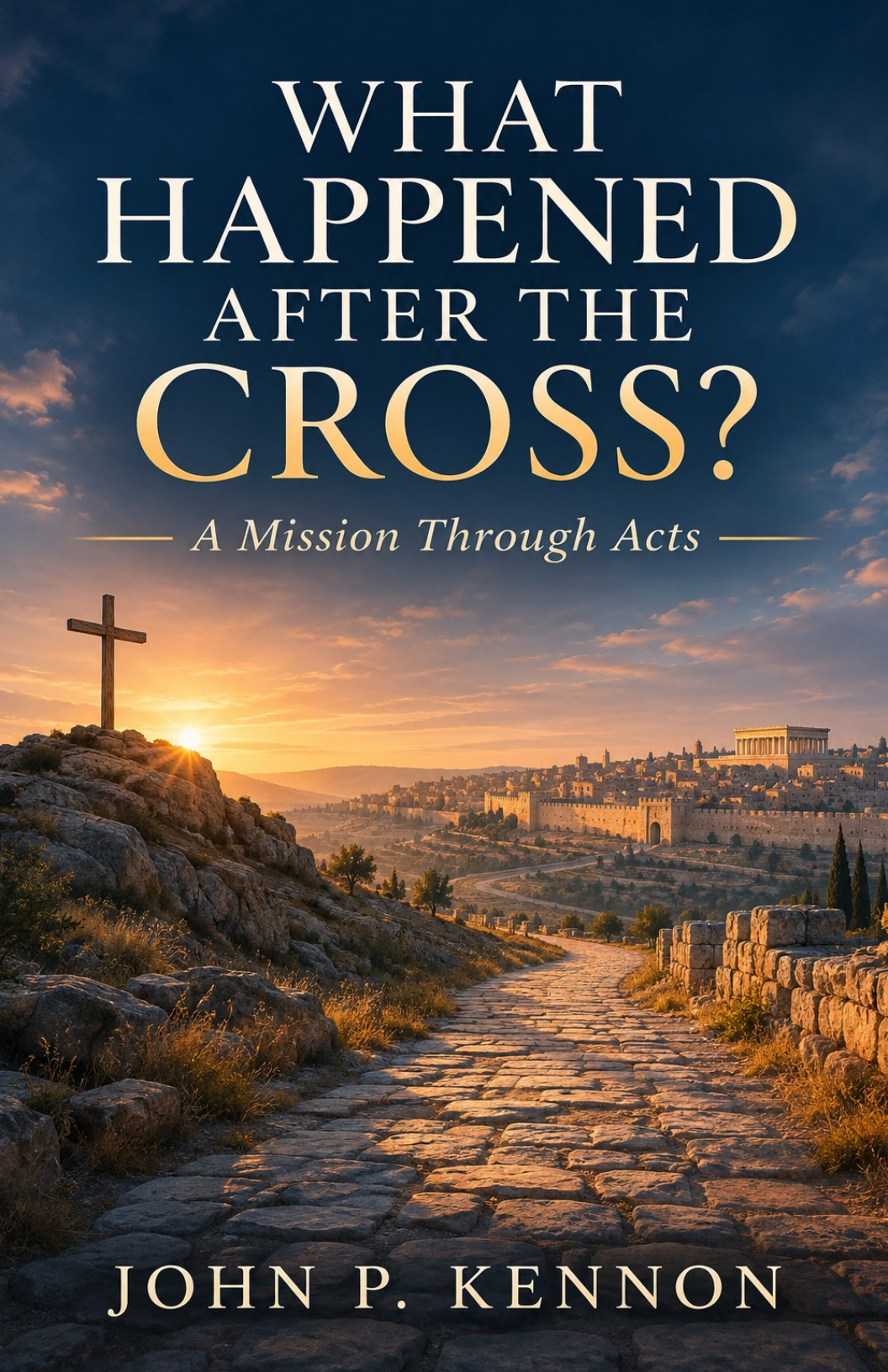
WHAT HAPPENED AFTER THE CROSS?

A Mission Through Acts



JOHN P. KENNON



“From Jerusalem’s Streets to the Ends of the Earth“

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Introduction: The Acts of the Apostles and the Ministry of the Saints

This book was born out of a powerful and consistent message from our pastor: The call to be a difference-maker in the Kingdom of God. True laborers in the faith are not simply spectators—they actively participate in the work of the Gospel. This is the ministry of the saints, operating under the leadership of the five-fold ministry—apostles, prophets, evangelists, pastors, and teachers (Ephesians 4:11).

But what exactly were the Acts of the Apostles?
What was their daily life like?
What kind of work did they do?
How did their faith influence their families and their communities?

While history does not provide us with every personal detail of Paul, Peter, John, and the other early church laborers, what we do have is a powerful record of

their actions—a collection of defining moments that give us insight into the foundation of the early church.

The Central Question: "How Were You Baptized?"

One question echoes throughout the Book of Acts: *"How then were you baptized?"*

This was not a minor detail for the apostles. It was a foundational truth—the very heart of the early church's growth and mission. The Acts of the Apostles revolve around this central theme: leading believers into the new birth experience as taught and demonstrated by Jesus.

Viewing Acts Through the Lens of the Cross

This book is designed for anyone seeking biblical truth about baptism and the new birth experience. It is a compilation of every example of biblical baptism recorded in Acts. However, to truly understand Acts, we must first look through the lens of the Cross.

A believer must first receive the revelation of the Cross—that Jesus died for their sins, was buried, and rose again. Faith begins with the understanding that Jesus' sacrifice made a way for salvation. But faith alone is not enough—we must respond in obedience, just as the apostles did.

By looking at the Book of Acts through the correct lens, we see that the apostles were not just preaching repentance; they were leading people into the full experience of salvation. They preached:

✓ Faith in Jesus Christ

✓ Baptism in Jesus' Name (Acts 2:38, Acts 8:16, Acts 10:48, Acts 19:5)

✓ The Infilling of the Holy Spirit (Acts 2:4, Acts 10:44-46, Acts 19:6)

The Apostolic Pattern of the New Birth

This book will explore the new birth as experienced by the apostles, using four distinct areas of study for each recorded event:

Location – Where did this event take place?

Circumstances – What led up to this moment?

Experience – What happened when the believer responded?

Conclusion – Is this experience consistent with other Acts accounts?

Structure of This Book

Each chapter will include three key components:

The Story – A narrative account based on scripture.

The ***Scriptural Reference*** – A direct look at what the Bible says.

The ***Historical Context*** – Insights from historical sources, including Josephus and the Preacher's Homiletical Commentary.

All ***Scriptural Reference***s are taken from the New King James Version (NKJV) to maintain clarity and accuracy.

A Prayer for Revelation

My prayer for you, dear reader, is the same prayer Paul prayed for the church. As you go through this book, I encourage you to pray earnestly for a spirit of wisdom and revelation to guide you into truth.

Ephesians 1:15-23 (NKJV)

"Therefore I also, after I heard of your faith in the Lord Jesus and your love for all the saints, do not cease to give thanks for you, making mention of you in my prayers: that the God of our Lord Jesus Christ, the Father of glory, may give to you the spirit of wisdom and revelation in the knowledge of Him, the eyes of your understanding being enlightened; that you may know what is the hope of His calling, what are the riches of the glory of His inheritance

in the saints, and what is the exceeding greatness of His power toward us who believe, according to the working of His mighty power which He worked in Christ when He raised Him from the dead and seated Him at His right hand in the heavenly places, far above all principality and power and might and dominion, and every name that is named, not only in this age but also in that which is to come. And He put all things under His feet, and gave Him to be head over all things to the church, which is His body, the fullness of Him who fills all in all."

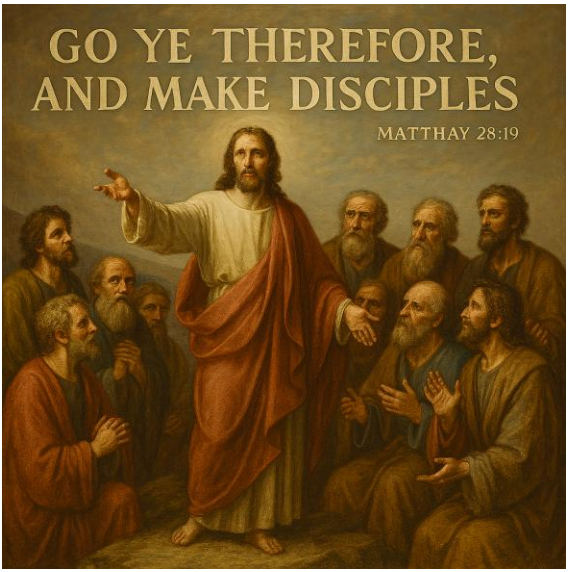
May the Lord open your understanding as you search the scriptures. May you see the apostolic pattern of salvation laid out in the Book of Acts. And may you be strengthened in faith, ready to receive and obey the full gospel of Jesus Christ.

Acts 2:38 (NKJV)

"Repent, and let every one of you be baptized in the name

of Jesus Christ for the remission of sins; and you shall receive the gift of the Holy Spirit."

Let us begin this journey—through the Acts of the Apostles and the power of the New Birth.



Relationship building thought

Before We Begin: *A Call to Transform Our View on Relationships*

Before diving into this subject, let's take a moment to reflect on something that can fundamentally change our approach—not just to this study, but to life itself.

We live in a relationship crisis of epic proportions, a crisis that has existed since the fall of Adam and Eve. From that moment, relationships—both with God and with one another—became broken, strained, and distorted. The evidence is everywhere: wars, jealousy, strife, deception, bitterness, hate, lust, and division. These forces, if left unchecked, work against relationships, tearing apart families, friendships, businesses, and even churches.

But here's the truth: God designed us for relationships. He never intended for us to live isolated, angry, or disconnected. His ultimate goal is to transform our understanding of relationships through love—a love that is not just about gaining knowledge but about a conversion of the heart and mind.

This transformation does not mean becoming a doormat for others to trample on. Rather, it means learning to walk in the wisdom and balance that Jesus taught:

Matthew 10:16 (NKJV)

"Behold, I send you out as sheep in the midst of wolves. Therefore be wise as serpents and harmless as doves."

This truth is simple yet profound. The garden of relationships depends on us to initiate, build, and maintain connections. Relationships do not flourish by accident; they must be nurtured, fed, and cared for. Yes, there will be those who do not reciprocate, but most will—because we were created for connection.

As Dr. Gary Smalley insightfully wrote in *The DNA of Relationships*:

"This world is in a relationship crisis."

If we examine failed businesses, broken families, fractured friendships, and struggling marriages, they all

share one common denominator—relationships. The quality of our relationships determines whether we thrive or struggle in every area of life.

As believers, we are called to do more than observe the problem—we are called to be the solution. If we truly desire to see revival, we must first break through the relationship barriers in our own lives and extend God's love to a hurting world. Healing broken relationships is not just a social need; it is a spiritual mission.

God's answer to a world in crisis is revival, but revival cannot come without reconciliation.

Let's embark on this journey with open hearts and renewed minds, knowing that through His Word, His Spirit, and His love, we can be part of the solution—not just in our own lives, but in the lives of those around us.

Lessons from the Garden: Nurturing Relationships God's Way

What we fail to nurture, protect, and invest in will eventually wither and die. This truth applies not only to plants but also to relationships. Just as Adam and Eve were cast out of the garden of perfect communion with God, the fall of humanity transformed our ability to have peaceful, fruitful relationships. Sin created barriers, division, and strife, replacing the harmony and unity that once existed in the garden.

The environment of this fallen world is no longer the peaceful paradise humanity once enjoyed. Brokenness, misunderstandings, and wounds can choke relationships if left unattended. This is why our approach to building and maintaining relationships must be transformed—it must reflect God's design, His image, and His likeness.

A Prayer for Relationships:

"Lord, lead us and guide us each step of the way. Help us to be intentional in sowing good seeds, watering them,

nurturing them, and protecting them. Just as You sustain and cultivate Your relationship with us, teach us to do the same with others. Amen."

God is not only the Creator of relationships, but He is also the One who initiates, sustains, nurtures, protects, and builds them. He teaches us to do the same. Nothing good grows by accident. Only weeds and tares seem to sprout effortlessly. But even those are left in God's hands until the final harvest (Matthew 13:24-30).

Devotional Action Step: ***Growing an Herb Garden***

Objective:

Help your family understand that healthy relationships require effort, time, and care—just like tending a garden.

Activity:

Purchase a small herb-growing kit for each family member. Gather everyone together and discuss how the success or failure of this plant's life depends on how well they do.

- Plant it properly.
- Water and nurture it.
- Protect it from harm.

Key Lesson:

✓ If nurtured properly, the plant will grow, and everyone can enjoy its fruit.

✓ If neglected, it will wither, and no one will benefit.

✓ If it dies, the only option is to start over.

✓ If it begins to struggle, it must be revived with extra care and attention.

This is exactly how relationships work.

Healthy relationships require intentional effort, time, prayer, patience, love, and nurture.

Broken relationships need rebuilding and restoration through prayerful effort.

Unhealthy relationships left unchecked can choke out the good fruit God wants to produce in our lives.

The Garden of Relationships & The Kingdom of God

Jesus compared the Kingdom of God to a growing seed (Mark 4:26-29). Relationships do not develop overnight; they require careful cultivation, just like a garden. Whether it is family, friendships, business connections, or evangelistic efforts, we are called to plant and water, and God gives the increase (1 Corinthians 3:6-7).

Building relationships takes deliberate effort, but a thriving garden will be a testimony to others. Those who

see a healthy, God-centered relationship will desire to learn how it was nurtured and sustained. This is how we make disciples—not just inside the church, but by investing in people outside the church and leading them into the Kingdom of God.

Final Thought: Relationships Are a Daily Commitment

Building strong, fruitful relationships is not a microwave process—it is a lifelong commitment. Every day, we have the opportunity to:

✓ Prepare the soil (build trust).

✓ Plant the seed (show love and truth).

✓ Water and protect (pray, nurture, and invest time).

✓ Wait patiently for growth (trusting God to work).

✓ Harvest the fruit (enjoy the blessings of deep, God-honoring relationships).

By committing to godly relationship-building, we not only create lifelong friendships and unity—we also bring others into the Kingdom of God. The relationships we cultivate outside of the church have the potential to produce disciples who will one day become part of the church.

Let us be faithful gardeners in God's Kingdom, tending to relationships with wisdom, love, and patience, so that His will can be accomplished in us and through us.

CHAPTER 1 ACTS OF THE APOSTLES

How Then Were You Baptized?

To understand true salvation, we must view it through the correct lens—one that brings clarity, not distortion. This lens consists of three essential elements that must agree as one:

Faith – The foundation of our belief in Jesus Christ.

The Message of the Cross – His death, burial, and resurrection as the only way to salvation.

The Word of God – The final and absolute authority that defines the path of salvation.

"One Lord, one faith, one baptism." (Ephesians 4:5, NKJV)

These three elements unite in one message of salvation—the very message preached by the apostles, who were sent by Jesus Himself.

Luke 24:47-49 (NKJV)

"And that repentance and remission of sins should be preached in His name to all nations, beginning at Jerusalem. And you are witnesses of these things. Behold, I send the Promise of My Father upon you; but tarry in the city of Jerusalem until you are endued with power from on high."

From the Resurrection to the Upper Room:

A Journey of Transformation

The apostles stood in stunned silence as the risen Jesus ascended into the heavens, disappearing behind a cloud. Just moments before, they had asked,

"Lord, will You at this time restore the kingdom to Israel?"

But Jesus had given them a different mission—not an earthly kingdom, but a spiritual one. They were to be witnesses of His name, beginning in Jerusalem and extending to the ends of the earth. And then, just as suddenly as He left, two angels appeared, assuring them that He would return.

With hearts pounding and minds racing, they made their way back to Jerusalem, clinging to Jesus' final instruction:

"Wait for the promise of the Father."

But what exactly did that mean?

They had walked with Jesus, seen His miracles, and witnessed His victory over death—yet something was still missing.

Gathering in the Upper Room, they were no longer the fearful men who had once scattered at His crucifixion. Faith had replaced doubt. Hope had silenced despair. Together with Mary, the mother of Jesus, and other disciples, they devoted themselves to prayer. They waited—not in uncertainty, but in expectation.

Then, on the Day of Pentecost, it happened.

🔥 A mighty rushing wind filled the room.

🔥 Tongues of fire rested on each of them.

🔥 They spoke in new languages as the Holy Spirit filled them.

The long-awaited promise had arrived.

No longer confused disciples, they emerged from the Upper Room transformed—bold, empowered, and ready to turn the world upside down with the message of Jesus Christ.

They were no longer just followers—they were now sent ones.

And their message began with a single question:

"How then were you baptized?" (Acts 19:3)

This question is not ancient history—it is just as relevant today.

So I ask you, in the most loving way possible:

How were you baptized?

First Principles:

The Lens Through Which We See Baptism

The way we view baptism will either distort our understanding or clear the path to revelation. It is not merely a religious practice—it is an essential response to the Gospel, a foundational doctrine that carries eternal significance.

To fully grasp the importance of baptism, we must first recognize three fundamental truths:

The Gospel is the death, burial, and resurrection of Jesus Christ—the finished work of Calvary.

The disciples acted on this belief, beginning in Jerusalem on the Day of Pentecost, as Jesus instructed.

Their experience of seeing the Gospel come full circle—from instruction to revelation to obedience—became the foundation of the Book of Acts.

The Book of Acts is not just history—it is the living blueprint for the New Testament church.

The Rule of Inference: A Key to Understanding Baptism

When studying biblical doctrine, there are eight hermeneutical rules of interpretation. Instead of analyzing all eight, we will focus on one crucial rule that clarifies the truth about baptism:

The Rule of Inference:

An inference is a fact reasonably implied from another fact. It is a logical conclusion derived from clear evidence. A biblical inference is binding when supported by competent and satisfactory proof—evidence that convinces an unbiased mind beyond reasonable doubt.

Jesus Himself used this rule of inference when He proved the resurrection of the dead to the unbelieving Sadducees (Matthew 22:23-33).

How does this apply to baptism?

Once the apostles received the Great Commission, they acted on it in Acts 2:38—preaching baptism in the name of Jesus Christ for the remission of sins. From that moment forward, this doctrine was permanently established in Scripture.

This is why Paul later declared:

"One Lord, one faith, one baptism." (Ephesians 4:5)

The apostles obeyed the Holy Spirit and laid down a doctrine so powerful that it has been fiercely debated, caused great upheavals in Christian history, and even led to martyrdom for those who refused to compromise this precious truth.

The Question That Defines Everything: How Were You Baptized?

This is not just a theological debate—it is a matter of life and death.

The Book of Acts is filled with this question. Whether in Jerusalem, Samaria, Ephesus, or Corinth, the apostles consistently asked new believers about their baptism. Why? Because baptism was not optional—it was the biblical response to faith in Christ.

And so today, in the most loving way possible, I ask you the same question:

"How were you baptized?"

This is not about religious tradition. This is about truth. This is about eternity.

The answer to this question matters more than anything else in your walk with God.

End of sample

Thank you for reading the opening of What Happened After the Cross?.

The full edition is being prepared for publication.

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